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Lethal Means Safety Counseling: Recommendations for Providers



What is lethal means safety counseling?

Lethal means safety counseling is a vital part of safety planning. It is a process to first assess whether patients are at risk for suicide, and then to work with them to restrict access to lethal means. Lethal means may include firearms, prescription medications, and lethal objects that could be used for suicidal self-directed violence.

When should I use lethal means counseling?



- When patients currently have suicidal thoughts.
- When patients in distress have attempted suicide in the past.
- When patients are struggling with mental health or substance use issues and are exhibiting risk factors, such as hopelessness, withdrawal or lacking reasons for living.
- When patients are struggling with stressful life events that may serve as triggers for suicidal behavior, such as financial, occupational or relationship problems.

A collaborative approach for addressing lethal means:

Raise the issue:

- Assess how lethal means such as firearms and medications are currently stored at home.

Develop a plan and recommend safe storage practices:



- Engage the support of family members when possible.
- Safely store firearms until the patient recovers.
- Reduce availability of medications.
- Reduce access to any other method about which a patient has expressed ideation.

Document and follow up:

- Be specific about roles and timeframe.
- Document the plan for safety and next steps.
- Confirm that the plan for safety was implemented.

Routine Safe Storage Options

Firearms: Most common method of suicide

- Store firearms unloaded in a locked gun safe.
- Store ammunition separately from firearms.
- Ensure locking device on firearms (cable locks or trigger locks).
- Store disassembled firearms.

Medications: Most common method of suicide attempts

- Keep only small quantities on hand. Consult a pharmacist for safe dosing practices and safety packaging as appropriate.
- Lock up abuse-prone medicines, such as opiates, benzodiazepines, sedatives, or hypnotics.
- Safely dispose of medications no longer in use.



Am I allowed to ask my patients about firearms?

- Yes. Federal law, DOD, and VA policies allow providers who are worried about suicidal behaviors to inquire about the patient's access to firearms and make recommendations to reduce suicide risk.¹



Am I allowed to inform commanders about suicide risk?

- Yes, a service member's chain of command has a "need to know" regarding suicide risk status, and such disclosures are authorized by DOD regulations in compliance with the Military Command Exception to the HIPAA Privacy Rule.² This also applies to National Guard and Reserve service members while on active duty or actively drilling.



Lethal Means Safety Counseling Suggestions for Providers^{3,4,5,6}



What are some options I can recommend to temporarily restrict access to firearms?

These options should be considered temporary. Patients should be reassured that the purpose of restriction is not to remove firearms permanently. Patients should be afforded the opportunity to get firearms back.

- Ask a relative or friend to take possession of firearms.
- Store firearms in a self-storage rental unit if permissible.
- Store firearms at a shooting range with available lockers.
- Store firearms at a gun shop for short period of time.
- Ask law enforcement to take possession of firearms.
- Personally owned firearms may be stored in military unit arms rooms.



Do

- Ask direct questions about firearm access on a routine basis and explain rationale for asking (e.g. to ensure safety).
- To determine best safety measures discuss patient's reasons for firearm ownership (e.g. work, hobbies, personal safety, collecting mementos).
- Engage relevant parties, including family members and commanders, in the process of means restriction counseling when recommending firearms restriction.
- Assess access to both military-issued and privately-owned firearms as a core component of risk assessment and safety planning.
- Be aware of state-specific and federal laws regarding the temporary transfer of firearms between individuals.
- Collaborate with all involved parties in the process of firearms restriction and process of removing firearms from the home when patient is at risk of suicide.
- Be aware of the potential impact of firearms restriction on unit readiness, deployability, and sense of self, and take care to use the least-restrictive method to ensure safety.
- Forge relationships with local Veteran Service Organizations as a potential mechanism for voluntary, short-term transfer of firearms to a trusted peer.



Don't

- Take possession of firearms.
- Encourage patient to bring firearms to medical clinics.
- Tell patients to "give away" their firearms.
- Ignore patient's values related to firearm ownership.
- Imply that a patient is incapable of carrying a firearm.
- Imply that a patient is "mentally unsound" from a legal perspective.

Resources



U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs Suicide Prevention

Contains resource links for free provider consultation regarding lethal means safety and counseling
mentalhealth.va.gov/suicide_prevention/



Real Warriors Campaign

Resources to decrease stigma, increase psychological health literacy, and open doors to access to care
health.mil/RealWarriors



Center for Deployment Psychology

Online training course titled Lethal Means Safety Counseling to Reduce Suicide Risk
deploymentpsych.org/Lethal_Mean_Safety_Archive

References:

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2. HIPAA Privacy Rule, 45 CFR § 164.512(k) (2002).
3. Hoyt, T., & Duffy, V. (2015). Implementing firearms restriction for preventing U.S. Army suicide. *Military Psychology*, 27, 384–390.
4. Hoyt, T., Holliday, R., Simonetti, J. A., & Monteith, L. L. (2021). Firearm lethal means safety with military personnel and veterans: Overcoming barriers using a collaborative approach. *Professional Psychology: Research and Practice*, 52(4), 387–395. doi: 10.1037/pro0000372.
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